

CULTIVARS

- New Red Fire
- Adriana
- Jericho
- Eruption

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 3 rows (12" - 30 cm) per bed spaced every 12" (30 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Lettuce will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Water consistently to avoid bitter taste. Critical to water before head development.

IMPLANTATION

We plant head lettuce every 2 weeks to ensure a constant supply throughout the season. For every seeding, we plan enough beds for an estimated 3 weeks of supply, using cultivars that have different DTM.

In our planting program, lettuce is often grouped with crops like green onions, rapini, bok choy, mini-romaine, mini-fennel, dill, cilantro and mini-kohlrabi — all crops that stay in the fields +/- 50 days and that have similar crop requirements.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- 30" bed prep rake + 3 marking tubes
- Popping tray

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed.*
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are about to transplant.
- Using the bed prep rake and 3 tubes, mark the rows both lengthways and sideways. Bring out the well-watered trays.
- Once the beds are ready, 1 person will drop the seedlings while another transplants as fast as possible. Lettuce transplants are very tough and don't need special care. 2 people/100' bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Install irrigation and water until the soil is deeply moistened.

* If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- Lettuce is cultivated only once using the collinear hoe 14 to 16 days after transplant, or earlier if the soil starts to crust.

PLANT PROTECTION

- No action is required

HARVEST

- Lettuce is harvested in the fields in a kneeling position.
- Harvesting is done using a VERY sharp knife. Sharpen your blades before each harvest; this will help reduce potential oxidation of the cut surface. Do not use carbon or rusted blades.
- In the pathway, 1 person harvests 2 rows at a time, pushing a bin in front of them. The third row is then harvested on the walk back up the bed. Remove slugs and dead or damaged leaves as necessary.
- Do not overfill bins, you need to be able to stack them without damaging the lettuces.

CONDITIONING

- The lettuce heads are washed by quickly dunking them in a sink full of cold water.
- Use both hands (one lettuce head in each hand) to shake out any excess and place them on a screen facing down to let them drip-dry for a moment. Make sure the lettuce is in the water for no more than a minute to avoid getting waterlogged.
- Pack the lettuces tightly in storage totes, stacking them upside down to let the water drain while sitting in the cooler.

STORING

- Lettuces are stored in cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not stay longer than 3 days before being sold.